

Lures & Baits

Pine Lake & North Lake

What to carry, and what each thing is actually for

A tackle box fills up with things that catch fishermen. This sheet is the short list that catches fish on these two lakes, with the reason each item exists. Buy depth and colour variety in the few categories that matter, not one of everything.

Hard baits

Lure	Size	What it is for and how to work it	Target
Inline spinner	1/8–1/4 oz	Steady retrieve, blade turning. The simplest lure that works. Excellent for a beginner because a constant speed is all it needs.	Panfish, bass, pike
Spinnerbait	3/8–3/4 oz	Safety-pin wire arm makes it near-weedless. Slow-roll it over and through weed tops. The pike lure on North Lake.	Pike, largemouth
Squarebill crankbait	2–2.5 in	Dives 3–6 ft and deflects off cover. Bump it into weeds and rock; the strike comes as it ricochets.	Largemouth, smallmouth
Deep crankbait	2.5–3 in	Dives 12–20 ft. Trolled or cast along a break. Fall walleye.	Walleye, pike
Suspending jerkbait	4–5 in	Twitch, twitch, <i>pause</i> . The pause is the presentation — count to five in cold water.	Smallmouth, walleye, pike
Casting spoon	1/2–1 oz	Flutters on the fall. Cast, count down, retrieve in sweeps. Also the standard ice jigging spoon.	Pike, walleye
Walking topwater	4 in	Rod-tip cadence makes it swing side to side. First and last light only.	Largemouth
Popper	2–3 in	Chug, pause, chug. Over shallow weed on calm summer mornings.	Largemouth, big bluegill

Soft plastics and jigs

Item	Size	What it is for	Rig it on
Stick worm	5 in	The single most productive bass bait on Pine Lake. Buy these before anything else.	see the <i>wacky rig</i> sheet, see the <i>Texas rig</i> sheet
Ribbon-tail worm	7 in	More action on the fall than a stick worm; better in stained water.	see the <i>Texas rig</i> sheet, see the <i>Carolina rig</i> sheet
Tube	3–4 in	Spirals and puffs like a fleeing crayfish. The best smallmouth bait there is.	Tube jig head
Craw / creature	3–4 in	Bulk and appendages. Punching weed and flipping wood.	see the <i>Texas rig</i> sheet
Minnow-shaped plastic	3–4 in	Slim profile that hangs horizontally.	see the <i>drop-shot</i> sheet
Round jig head	1/16–3/8 oz	Weight and hook in one. Carry the whole range — depth dictates weight.	see the <i>jig-and-minnow</i> sheet
Panfish jig	1/32–1/16 oz	Tiny hair or plastic jig under a float or on its own.	see the <i>slip bobber</i> sheet
Bass jig & trailer	3/8–1/2 oz	Weedguard and a skirt. Slow, deliberate, big-fish bait around wood and weed edges.	Direct tie

Live bait

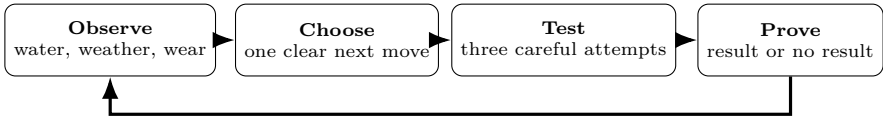
Bait	When and why	Hook it
Nightcrawler	The universal bait. Half a crawler out-fishes a whole one for panfish, because a small mouth cannot get the whole thing.	Thread on, leave a short tail moving
Leech	The best walleye bait from late May through summer. Swims with a ribbon motion nothing imitates.	Once through the sucker end
Fathead minnow	Cold water: ice-out through May, and October on. Hardy in the bucket.	Up through both lips
Golden shiner	Bigger, flashier, more fragile. Pike and walleye.	Through the back, behind the dorsal
Sucker (dead, 6–10 in)	Winter and cold-water pike. Dead bait works — pike scavenge.	see the <i>quick-strike rig sheet</i>
Waxworm / spike	Ice fishing and tight-lipped summer panfish.	One or two on a tiny jig
Crayfish	The premium smallmouth bait on Pine Lake’s gravel.	Plain hook through the tail, one split shot

Colour, in one paragraph

Pine Lake is very clear: natural and translucent colours — green pumpkin, watermelon, smoke, silver, real crayfish brown. North Lake is stained: brighter and more solid — chartreuse, white, black, gold, firetiger. In both lakes, black or dark purple is the most visible silhouette in low light and at night. If you only ever carry three soft-plastic colours, carry green pumpkin, black, and white.

Do not move live bait between waters. Wisconsin has strict rules on transporting live fish and water to prevent spreading invasive species and disease. Drain everything, and dispose of unused bait in the trash rather than the lake. Confirm the current bait rules with the DNR — they are enforced.

Use a closed-loop check



Question	Check	Recovery
What changed?	Name one visible or measurable fact: wind direction, depth, water temperature, abrasion, knot shape, lure track, fish reflex, or elapsed time.	If you cannot name the change, observe for one minute before changing equipment.
What am I testing?	Change one variable only and state what success will look like before the attempt.	Restore the last known setup; avoid changing lure, depth, speed, and location together.
Is the system sound?	Trace the full chain from hand to fish: line, knot, leader, hook, drag, handling tool, route home.	Stop on any rough line, crossed wrap, open snap, dull point, missing tool, or unsafe condition; repair or leave.
What proves completion?	A repeatable result and a final tactile/visual check, not merely finishing the written steps.	Repeat slowly under good light. If the check is ambiguous, treat it as a failure.

Final proof before the next cast

Say the plan in one sentence. Tug-test the terminal connection, touch-check the last two feet of line, confirm hook point and snap closure, set the drag, and identify the safe landing and release route. If weather, visibility, footing, or fish

condition makes that route doubtful, change the plan before casting.

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